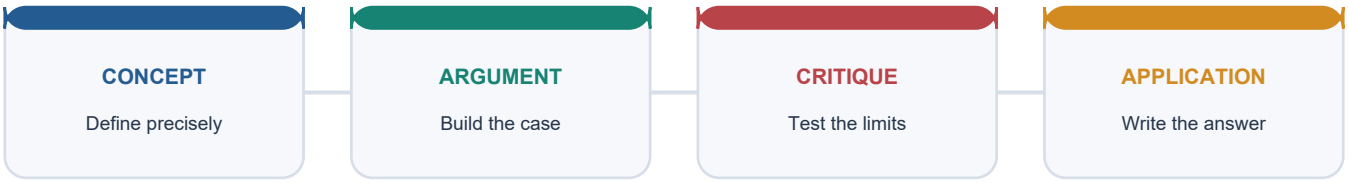
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Tughlaqs: Muhammad bin Tughlaq & Firuz Shah - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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The Tughlaqs: Muhammad bin Tughlaq & Firuz Shah - Solved Practice Workbook

Rotation check rule: this workbook carries 32 original Workbook MCQs whose correct options rotate strictly **A -> B -> C -> D**, repeated eight times. Every option receives its own explanation, and every question closes on a distinct trap line. The sixteen teaching-loop questions inside the main learning session are not repeated here.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Workbook MCQ 01

Question: Tughlaqabad is best understood as:

- A. a fortified dynastic statement of military austerity and new legitimacy.
- B. a pleasure garden with no political meaning.
- C. a Portuguese warehouse.
- D. a Mughal observatory.

Answer: A - a fortified dynastic statement of military austerity and new legitimacy.

- A. **Correct.** The fortress-capital, together with Ghiyasuddin's elevated domed tomb, announced a new dynastic idiom of austere fortified strength in place of ornament.
- B. **Incorrect.** Tughlaqabad's battered walls, high platforms and fortified circuit are defensive and ceremonial architecture; nothing in the complex resembles a pleasure garden.
- C. **Incorrect.** Portuguese establishments in India begin after 1498, more than one hundred and seventy years after Tughlaqabad was built.
- D. **Incorrect.** Mughal rule begins in 1526, and the observatory tradition associated with Jai Singh belongs to the eighteenth century.

Trap: Reading a fourteenth-century fortress-capital as decoration, or as a later Portuguese or Mughal structure, instead of as a dynastic legitimacy statement.

Workbook MCQ 02

Question: Which is the safest statement regarding Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq's death?

- A. It is fully proved as a saintly curse.
- B. The secure event is the pavilion collapse; conspiracy and curse narratives belong to layered and disputed source traditions.
- C. It is fully proved as a deliberate murder by Muhammad bin Tughlaq.
- D. There is no source at all about the event.

Answer: B - The secure event is the pavilion collapse; conspiracy and curse narratives belong to layered and disputed source traditions.

- A. **Incorrect.** The Nizamuddin Auliya curse belongs to a legendary layer of the tradition and cannot be tested as historical evidence.
- B. **Correct.** The secure minimum is the collapse of the welcome pavilion at Afghanpur in 1325; accident, negligence and conspiracy remain distinct and unresolved source layers.
- C. **Incorrect.** Contemporary suspicion existed, but the advanced source states that modern research does not support a proved murderous conspiracy.
- D. **Incorrect.** Barani, Ibn Battuta and later traditions all report the episode, so the difficulty is contradiction between the sources rather than their silence.

Trap: Choosing certainty where the evidence supports only a layered account, either by convicting Muhammad or by promoting the curse legend to the status of fact.

Workbook MCQ 03

Question: The choice of Daulatabad was politically meaningful chiefly because:

- A. it lay closest to Tibet.
- B. it had no settled population.
- C. Devagiri was already a strategic Deccan base and more central to the enlarged imperial space.
- D. it had never been touched by Delhi before.

Answer: C - Devagiri was already a strategic Deccan base and more central to the enlarged imperial space.

- A. **Incorrect.** Daulatabad lies in the northern Deccan; the Himalayan direction belongs to the entirely separate Qarachil expedition.
- B. **Incorrect.** Deogir was an established Yadava capital with an existing population and fortifications, which is part of why it was selected.
- C. **Correct.** Devagiri had been raided by Alauddin, used later as a Delhi base and commanded by Muhammad himself as prince, so it was a known node closer to the enlarged empire's centre.
- D. **Incorrect.** Delhi had campaigned against and extracted tribute from Devagiri since Alauddin's raid, so the connection long predated the renaming.

Trap: Treating the second capital as an arbitrary site instead of a pre-existing Deccan base that Delhi had already raided, used and governed.

Workbook MCQ 04

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Muhammad emptied Delhi completely"?

- A. Daulatabad never existed.
- B. No movement occurred at all.
- C. Only Bengal was moved.
- D. He imposed severe movement pressure, but mainly on elites and associated groups; Delhi remained inhabited and functioning.

Answer: D - He imposed severe movement pressure, but mainly on elites and associated groups; Delhi remained inhabited and functioning.

- A. **Incorrect.** Deogir was renamed Daulatabad and developed with an organised road, ward divisions and housing grants; denying the project replaces one error with another.
- B. **Incorrect.** The sources record organised, coerced migration and real hardship on the journey, so the correction is against totality, not against movement.
- C. **Incorrect.** Bengal was a recurrently centrifugal province, not a source of migrants to the Deccan; this confuses two separate strands of the reign.
- D. **Correct.** Pressure fell chiefly on officers, nobles, leading men, Sufis, ulema, merchants and artisans, while Delhi retained both its population and its mint.

Trap: Over-correcting the emptied-Delhi myth into a denial that any coerced migration, surveillance or hardship took place at all.

Workbook MCQ 05

Question: Which description of Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token currency is historically incorrect?

- A. paper currency.
- B. fiduciary coinage.
- C. a policy undermined by forgery.
- D. a monetary experiment tied to credibility.

Answer: A - paper currency.

- A. **Correct.** The coins were copper and brass; calling them paper currency imports the Chinese precedent into India and misstates the physical object.
- B. **Incorrect.** Fiduciary is exactly the right description, because the metal's intrinsic worth lay below the value the state declared for it.
- C. **Incorrect.** Private imitation and the inability to authenticate official issue form the package's central explanation of the failure.
- D. **Incorrect.** Credibility is the correct analytical frame, since a declared value survives only while the public trusts the issuer.

Trap: Repeating the textbook line that Muhammad bin Tughlaq issued paper money, when the paper precedent named by the sources is Chinese rather than Indian.

Workbook MCQ 06

Question: What most directly ruined the token-currency experiment?

- A. A total absence of military expenditure.
- B. Failure to maintain trust by controlling authentication and counterfeiting.
- C. Refusal of all nobles to accept any metal coin.
- D. The closing of all mints by order of Firuz Shah.

Answer: B - Failure to maintain trust by controlling authentication and counterfeiting.

- A. **Incorrect.** Military spending was heavy, and Barani connects the issue to military ambition rather than to any absence of it.
- B. **Correct.** Without a mint monopoly and a workable test of authenticity the state could not separate its own issue from imitations, and confidence collapsed.
- C. **Incorrect.** The problem was the acceptance of too many coins of uncertain origin, not a boycott of metal currency by the nobility.
- D. **Incorrect.** The experiment was withdrawn by Muhammad himself, decades before Firuz Shah's accession in 1351.

Trap: Attributing the collapse to novelty, to elite hostility or to a later reign, instead of to the missing verification machinery.

Workbook MCQ 07

Question: Which feature of the doab policy most sharply increased the effective burden on cultivators?

- A. Replacing officials with village assemblies only.
- B. Complete abolition of revenue demand.
- C. Assessment by standard yield and official prices rather than actual output and market reality.
- D. Free canal irrigation for all India.

Answer: C - Assessment by standard yield and official prices rather than actual output and market reality.

- A. **Incorrect.** Collection remained firmly in official hands and was intensified, with cattle branded and houses counted.
- B. **Incorrect.** The crisis arose from a raised and rigidly enforced demand, not from any remission of revenue.
- C. **Correct.** Standard yield and official prices fix the demand against a notional harvest and a notional market, so the real burden rises whenever output or prices fall.
- D. **Incorrect.** Canal irrigation belongs to Firuz's later northern programme and carried a water charge; it was never offered free across India.

Trap: Reading the doab crisis as a simple increase in the tax rate rather than as a change in the method of assessment operating under famine conditions.

Workbook MCQ 08

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's move to Swargadwari in the famine phase indicates:

- A. his conversion into a forest ascetic.
- B. permanent abandonment of Delhi for Bengal.
- C. the start of the Bahmani kingdom.
- D. the severity of scarcity and pestilential conditions around Delhi during the agrarian crisis.

Answer: D - the severity of scarcity and pestilential conditions around Delhi during the agrarian crisis.

- A. **Incorrect.** The move was an administrative and sanitary response to crisis conditions, not a religious withdrawal from rule.
- B. **Incorrect.** Swargadwari was a temporary camp; Bengal in this reign is a rebellious province rather than a royal residence.
- C. **Incorrect.** The Bahmani breakaway occurred in the Deccan near Daulatabad and belongs to a separate strand of the reign.
- D. **Correct.** The advanced source links the move to famine, rising grain prices, relief camps, grain brought from Awadh and pestilential conditions around Delhi.

Trap: Detaching the Swargadwari camp from the doab famine sequence and presenting it as an eccentric personal decision.

Workbook MCQ 09

Question: The most careful interpretation of Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi is that it aimed to:

- A. extend cultivation onto banjar land while improving crops through loans and supervision.
- B. create a seaborne customs network.
- C. destroy cultivated land in the doab.
- D. replace nobles with village priests.

Answer: A - extend cultivation onto banjar land while improving crops through loans and supervision.

- A. **Correct.** The advanced source insists the target was banjar or fallow land, worked through sondhar loans and supervised by about a hundred appointed shiqdars.
- B. **Incorrect.** The department was agricultural; no maritime or customs institution is attributed to it anywhere in the sources.
- C. **Incorrect.** Its stated purpose was to extend cultivation and improve crop quality after the doab crisis, not to remove land from production.
- D. **Incorrect.** The scheme appointed shiqdars as revenue-development officials; it did not restructure the nobility or transfer office to priests.

Trap: Accepting Barani's sharper wording that genuinely barren usar soil was being farmed, which converts a risky programme into an absurdity.

Workbook MCQ 10

Question: What is the safest caution when discussing the Khurasan project?

- A. It had no relation to the north-west frontier.
- B. Chroniclers inflate its scale and aim, so it should be treated as a strategic frontier project rather than automatic proof of world-conquest fantasy.
- C. It was identical to the Qarachil expedition.
- D. It certainly conquered Iraq.

Answer: B - Chroniclers inflate its scale and aim, so it should be treated as a strategic frontier project rather than automatic proof of world-conquest fantasy.

- A. **Incorrect.** The project arose directly from Transoxianan, Iranian, Ghazni and Afghan frontier politics after the Tarmashirin episode.
- B. **Correct.** The defensible reading limits the aim to a forward frontier and prestige objective and marks the reported scale as chronicler claim rather than audited fact.
- C. **Incorrect.** Khurasan was a plan supported by recruitment; Qarachil was an executed Himalayan campaign with an entirely different failure mode.
- D. **Incorrect.** The army was never launched as envisaged, and Iraq appears only in Barani's expanded phrasing about the aim.

Trap: Converting Barani's expansive phrasing about Khurasan and Iraq into proof of a coherent transcontinental conquest programme.

Workbook MCQ 11

Question: The Qarachil expedition is best described as:

- A. a purely maritime expedition to Arabia.
- B. the founding of Firozabad.
- C. a Himalayan campaign wrecked by terrain and over-extension.
- D. the abolition of jizya.

Answer: C - a Himalayan campaign wrecked by terrain and over-extension.

- A. **Incorrect.** No naval enterprise toward Arabia is attributed to the reign in any of the sources used here.
- B. **Incorrect.** Firozabad on the Yamuna is Firuz Shah's urban foundation, not a campaign undertaken by Muhammad bin Tughlaq.
- C. **Correct.** The advanced source places the campaign in the Kulu-Kangra and Kumaon-Kashmir horizon, where terrain, climate and supply destroyed the force.
- D. **Incorrect.** Jizya was not abolished; Firuz later made it a separate tax and extended it to Brahmans.

Trap: Repeating the later claim that Qarachil was an invasion of China, which the advanced source explicitly rejects.

Workbook MCQ 12

Question: Which statement best connects Muhammad bin Tughlaq's southern losses to later regional states?

- A. Delhi's southern failures automatically created a stable pan-Indian federation.
- B. The south remained completely unaffected by Delhi's crises.
- C. Bengal created the Bahmani state.
- D. Plague, distance and repeated rebellion weakened Delhi's direct rule, creating the setting for successor powers such as Vijayanagara and Bahmani.

Answer: D - Plague, distance and repeated rebellion weakened Delhi's direct rule, creating the setting for successor powers such as Vijayanagara and Bahmani.

- A. **Incorrect.** The outcome was fragmentation into competing successor states, not a federation of any kind.
- B. **Incorrect.** The far south is precisely where Delhi's control collapsed first and most completely.
- C. **Incorrect.** The Bahmani breakaway came from foreign nobles near Daulatabad in the Deccan, not from Bengal.
- D. **Correct.** Plague during the Mabar campaign, sheer distance and repeated revolt broke Delhi's direct rule, and Harihara and Bukka and the Bahmani founders emerged in that setting.

Trap: Importing the full institutional history of Vijayanagara or the Bahmani kingdom into Topic 05, which owns only the Delhi-side conditions that allowed them to form.

Workbook MCQ 13

Question: What is the chief limitation of Ibn Battuta for reconstructing the Tughlaq state?

- A. He is strongest on courtly and travel experience, not on comprehensive village-level structural data.
- B. He never visited India.
- C. He served only Firuz Shah.
- D. He wrote only about Gupta temples.

Answer: A - He is strongest on courtly and travel experience, not on comprehensive village-level structural data.

- A. **Correct.** His strength is courtly ceremony, punishments, gifts, roads, products and urban scale, and the concise source notes his limited interest in ordinary lives.
- B. **Incorrect.** He lived for years at Muhammad bin Tughlaq's court and held judicial office there, which is why his testimony matters.
- C. **Incorrect.** His Indian service belongs to Muhammad bin Tughlaq's reign, not to Firuz Shah's.
- D. **Incorrect.** The Gupta period ends centuries earlier; his subject is the fourteenth-century Sultanate.

Trap: Treating an eyewitness traveller's vividness as statistically representative evidence about village society.

Workbook MCQ 14

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Barani's dramatic numbers and moral language can be taken literally throughout"?

- A. His account was written by Ibn Battuta.
- B. Barani is indispensable but rhetorical, later and aristocratic, so his claims require cross-checking and minimum-secure phrasing.
- C. Barani is useless and should be ignored.
- D. Material evidence can never check narrative.

Answer: B - Barani is indispensable but rhetorical, later and aristocratic, so his claims require cross-checking and minimum-secure phrasing.

- A. **Incorrect.** The Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi and the Fatawa-i Jahandari are Barani's own compositions, not Ibn Battuta's.
- B. **Correct.** Barani writes later, from an aristocratic position and in a rhetorical register, so his figures and speeches require cross-checking and minimum-secure phrasing.
- C. **Incorrect.** He is indispensable for the policy sequence, elite ideology and the experiments themselves, so total rejection destroys the evidence base.
- D. **Incorrect.** Coins, canals, forts and pillars are exactly the corrective the package applies to literary claims.

Trap: Swinging from literal acceptance of Barani's rhetoric to wholesale rejection of the only detailed narrative the reign possesses.

Workbook MCQ 15

Question: Why must the *Futuhat-i Firuz Shahi* be read carefully?

- A. Because it deals only with Portuguese trade.
- B. Because it contains no political material.
- C. Because it is a ruler's self-presentation and must be checked against other narrative and material evidence.
- D. Because it was written by Chengiz Khan.

Answer: C - Because it is a ruler's self-presentation and must be checked against other narrative and material evidence.

- A. **Incorrect.** It is a fourteenth-century record of Firuz's works and religious policy, composed long before Portuguese arrival.
- B. **Incorrect.** Its account of taxation, orthodoxy and public works is intensely political throughout.
- C. **Correct.** It is the ruler's preferred account of himself and must be checked against other narrative and material evidence.
- D. **Incorrect.** Chengiz Khan belongs to the early thirteenth-century Mongol expansion, not to Tughlaq Delhi.

Trap: Using a ruler's own self-presentation as a neutral audit of his reign's achievements.

Workbook MCQ 16

Question: Why are coins, canals, forts and pillars important alongside chronicles in Topic 05?

- A. They matter only for ancient history.
- B. They prove that every chronicle number is exact.
- C. They replace all written sources completely.
- D. They anchor claims in material action while reminding us that physical survival does not automatically equal full administrative control.

Answer: D - They anchor claims in material action while reminding us that physical survival does not automatically equal full administrative control.

- A. **Incorrect.** Delhi mint continuity, Tughlaqabad, Kotla Firoz Shah and the transported pillars are all medieval material evidence.
- B. **Incorrect.** Material survival confirms activity but cannot verify reported totals of slaves, troops or tankas.
- C. **Incorrect.** Without the chronicles the material record would carry no policy narrative against which it could be tested.
- D. **Correct.** They anchor literary claims in demonstrable action while reminding the reader that surviving fabric is not proof of uniform administrative control.

Trap: Treating monuments and coins either as decorative background or as an omniscient substitute for the written record.

Workbook MCQ 17

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's turn toward caliphal investiture and the Caliph's name on coins is best explained as:

- A. an attempt to answer orthodox hostility by reinforcing symbolic legitimacy.
- B. a rejection of all Islamic political language.
- C. a sign that Bengal had become the capital.
- D. a revenue measure to fund canal digging under Firuz.

Answer: A - an attempt to answer orthodox hostility by reinforcing symbolic legitimacy.

- A. **Correct.** After qazis issued a fatwa making rebellion legally possible, the Sultan placed the Caliph's name on his coins and later obtained a manshur from the Cairo Abbasid line.
- B. **Incorrect.** Seeking caliphal recognition intensifies Islamic political language rather than rejecting it.
- C. **Incorrect.** Bengal was a breakaway province; the capitals in question are Delhi and Daulatabad.
- D. **Incorrect.** Canal digging belongs to Firuz Shah's later reign and had no connection with caliphal recognition.

Trap: Reading the caliphal rescript as evidence of piety alone, when its immediate function was to answer a juristic challenge to the Sultan's authority.

Workbook MCQ 18

Question: Which summary of Firuz Shah's military career is the safest?

- A. Complete military inactivity.
- B. Mixed campaigns in Bengal, Jajnagar, Nagarkot and Sindh, combined with refusal to attempt southern reconquest.
- C. Total reconquest of the south and Bengal alike.
- D. Exclusive focus on sea-borne warfare.

Answer: B - Mixed campaigns in Bengal, Jajnagar, Nagarkot and Sindh, combined with refusal to attempt southern reconquest.

- A. **Incorrect.** The Bengal, Jajnagar, Nagarkot and Thatta campaigns show sustained if deliberately limited campaigning.
- B. **Correct.** Two Bengal campaigns failed, Jajnagar and Nagarkot produced plunder or acknowledgement without annexation, Thatta proved costly, and no southern reconquest was attempted.
- C. **Incorrect.** Bengal remained independent and the south was never recovered during the reign.
- D. **Incorrect.** All the named campaigns were land operations in eastern, hill and lower-Indus theatres.

Trap: Flattening a mixed military record into either a wholly peaceful reign or a successful reconquest.

Workbook MCQ 19

Question: Under Firuz Shah, many soldiers of the central army were paid through:

- A. a fully salaried navy based at Cambay.
- B. temple management rights in Odisha.
- C. village-revenue assignments known as *wajh*.
- D. only imported Venetian silver.

Answer: C - village-revenue assignments known as wajh.

- A. **Incorrect.** No standing naval establishment of this kind is attributed to Firuz Shah in the sources used here.
- B. **Incorrect.** Jajnagar was raided rather than administered, and no temple endowments were assigned to Delhi's soldiers.
- C. **Correct.** Large parts of the army were paid by assignments on village revenue, which reinforced heredity and the localisation of military claims.
- D. **Incorrect.** The whole point of wajh is that soldiers were paid in revenue claims rather than in imported cash.

Trap: Confusing a revenue assignment made for military pay with either a cash salary or outright private landownership.

Workbook MCQ 20

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "hereditary iqtas were an unqualified administrative success"?

- A. Heredity instantly revived the Deccan.
- B. Heredity ended all faction.
- C. The policy abolished all noble privilege.
- D. The policy purchased short-term calm but weakened merit, discipline and central control in the long run.

Answer: D - The policy purchased short-term calm but weakened merit, discipline and central control in the long run.

- A. **Incorrect.** The Deccan had already been lost and Firuz made no attempt at its reconquest.
- B. **Incorrect.** Heredity produced entrenched office-holding families and, alongside the slave corps, sharpened faction after 1388.
- C. **Incorrect.** It did the opposite of abolishing privilege, converting revocable state grants into expected family entitlements.

- D. **Correct.** Heredity purchased noble peace while weakening merit, muster discipline and the centre's audit leverage.

Trap: Judging the hereditary settlement only by the calm of Firuz's own reign while ignoring the succession collapse it prepared.

Workbook MCQ 21

Question: Why is Firuz Shah's jizya policy important for Topic 05?

- A. It illustrates Firuz's sharper juristic ordering of rule, including denial of the earlier practical Brahman exemption.
- B. It proves that all other taxes vanished overnight.
- C. It had no relation to orthodoxy.
- D. It shows that Brahmans became army commanders by right.

Answer: A - It illustrates Firuz's sharper juristic ordering of rule, including denial of the earlier practical Brahman exemption.

- A. **Correct.** Making jizya a distinct levy and refusing the Brahmans' practical exemption is the clearest marker of Firuz's sharper juristic ordering.
- B. **Incorrect.** Land revenue, the irrigation charge and other levies continued alongside it throughout the reign.
- C. **Incorrect.** Its separation and extension were part of presenting the whole tax order as juristically correct.
- D. **Incorrect.** The change removed a fiscal exemption; it created no military entitlement of any kind.

Trap: Detaching the jizya decision from the wider bargain with the ulema that also produced bans, sectarian action and temple coercion.

Workbook MCQ 22

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Firuz's canals transformed every corner of the old Delhi empire equally"?

- A. The canals were built by Timur.
- B. The works were concentrated in the north-Indian core and should not be inflated into empire-wide equal development.
- C. There were no canals at all.
- D. All canals were in Bengal only.

Answer: B - The works were concentrated in the north-Indian core and should not be inflated into empire-wide equal development.

- A. **Incorrect.** Timur's invasion of 1398-99 was destructive rather than constructive, and belongs to Topic 06.
- B. **Correct.** The works lie in the Haryana-Delhi tract and around Hissar; no comparable investment reached the lost southern provinces.
- C. **Incorrect.** The Sutlej and Yamuna channels and the associated water charge are securely attested in the advanced source.
- D. **Incorrect.** Bengal was independent for most of the reign and received no such programme.

Trap: Inflating a geographically concentrated irrigation programme into empire-wide agrarian development.

Workbook MCQ 23

Question: Which statement about Firuz Shah's architectural and urban activity is the safest?

- A. He had no connection at all with Hauz Khas or Kotla.
- B. Every later city in north India was entirely his foundation.
- C. He founded or renewed important urban sites, repaired earlier monuments and must be discussed with careful attribution rather than inflated total credit.
- D. He destroyed all older monuments and built only new ones.

Answer: C - He founded or renewed important urban sites, repaired earlier monuments and must be discussed with careful attribution rather than inflated total credit.

- A. **Incorrect.** He repaired the Hauz Khas complex and founded Firozabad, whose fort survives as Kotla Firoz Shah.
- B. **Incorrect.** Jaunpur's major development is Sharqi, and several attributions to Firuz are later accretions.
- C. **Correct.** He founded and renewed urban sites and repaired earlier monuments, so credit must be assigned work by work rather than wholesale.
- D. **Incorrect.** The reign is notable for repair and reuse, including work on the damaged upper portions of the Qutb Minar.

Trap: Awarding Firuz blanket credit for the whole Qutb Minar or for every town later associated with his name.

Workbook MCQ 24

Question: Which architectural feature is most closely associated with Tughlaq style in this package?

- A. Neo-classical porticoes.
- B. Extensive marble pietra dura panels.
- C. Circular Buddhist railings.
- D. Battered or sloping walls combined with an austere fortified idiom.

Answer: D - Battered or sloping walls combined with an austere fortified idiom.

- A. **Incorrect.** Neo-classical porticoes belong to colonial-era building in India, several centuries after the Tughlaqs.
- B. **Incorrect.** Inlaid marble panelling belongs to seventeenth-century Mughal work, not to the Tughlaq idiom.
- C. **Incorrect.** Vedika railings belong to early historic Buddhist stupa architecture, a wholly different tradition.
- D. **Correct.** Battered or sloping walls with an austere fortified idiom, grey stone and high platforms mark the dynasty's style from Tughlaqabad onward.

Trap: Assigning later Mughal or colonial decorative vocabulary to a fourteenth-century fortified style built for strength rather than ornament.

Workbook MCQ 25

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "the slave department was mainly a welfare institution"?

- A. It organised coerced labour, service and political dependence rather than universal social protection.
- B. It was a merchants' port trust.
- C. It built Tughlaqabad before 1320.
- D. It regulated Brahman taxes only.

Answer: A - It organised coerced labour, service and political dependence rather than universal social protection.

- A. **Correct.** The Diwan-i-Bandagan organised coerced labour, karkhana production, palace service and an armed corps dependent on the ruler.
- B. **Incorrect.** It was a household, workshop and military establishment rather than a commercial body.
- C. **Incorrect.** Tughlaqabad is Ghiyasuddin's fortress, built decades before Firuz Shah's accession.
- D. **Incorrect.** Jizya on Brahmans was a fiscal decision of the reign, unconnected with the slave department.

Trap: Reading a department that administered unfree labour as a charitable or welfare institution.

Workbook MCQ 26

Question: What is the sharpest limitation in calling Firuz Shah a "welfare monarch"?

- A. He ruled only in the Deccan.
- B. Much of the benevolence was selective, politically useful and concentrated among favoured or respectable groups rather than universally distributed.
- C. He never undertook any charitable measure.
- D. He abolished all hospitals.

Answer: B - Much of the benevolence was selective, politically useful and concentrated among favoured or respectable groups rather than universally distributed.

- A. **Incorrect.** His effective rule was the north-Indian core; the Deccan had already been lost before his accession.
- B. **Correct.** The advanced source suggests much of the help was aimed at Muslims of respectable family fallen on hard times, especially around the capital.
- C. **Incorrect.** Hospitals, marriage assistance and restored grants to scholars and shrines are all well attested.
- D. **Incorrect.** He opened hospitals offering free treatment rather than closing them.

Trap: Answering a question about the limits of benevolence by denying that any benevolence existed.

Workbook MCQ 27

Question: Firuz Shah's patronage of translations from Sanskrit into Persian should lead to which conclusion?

- A. Orthodoxy disappeared from the reign.
- B. Jizya lost all significance.
- C. Cultural interest and orthodox state-marking could coexist in the same reign.
- D. The ulema had no role in politics.

Answer: C - Cultural interest and orthodox state-marking could coexist in the same reign.

- A. **Incorrect.** Jizya, sectarian persecution and temple action continue through the very same reign.
- B. **Incorrect.** Jizya became more prominent rather than less once it was separated and extended to Brahmans.
- C. **Correct.** Patronage of Sanskrit works on medicine, music and mathematics coexisted with sharper juristic marking of religious hierarchy.
- D. **Incorrect.** Ulema influence grew, and much of the reign's religious policy was designed to satisfy them.

Trap: Using cultural patronage to cancel the evidence of coercion, or coercion to cancel the evidence of patronage.

Workbook MCQ 28

Question: Which factor most directly worsened post-1388 instability?

- A. Immediate reconquest of Madurai by Delhi.
- B. Elimination of all provincial governors.
- C. Permanent unity between princes and wazirs.
- D. Interaction of hereditary office, factional nobles, ambitious princes and the slave corps.

Answer: D - Interaction of hereditary office, factional nobles, ambitious princes and the slave corps.

- A. **Incorrect.** Madurai had been independent since Muhammad's reign and was never recovered.
- B. **Incorrect.** Governors in Gujarat, Malwa, Khandesh and Jaunpur asserted autonomy rather than disappearing.
- C. **Incorrect.** Conflict between Prince Muhammad and the wazir Khan-i-Jahan II had begun even before Firuz died.
- D. **Correct.** Hereditary office, factional nobles, ambitious princes and the slave corps interacted to make every succession contestable.

Trap: Looking for a single culprit in the succession crisis when the instability came from several courtly constituencies at once.

Workbook MCQ 29

Question: Timur's later invasion should be connected to Topic 05 in which way?

- A. As a culminating shock that struck a Sultanate already weakened by earlier structural and succession problems.
- B. As proof that Firuz recovered the Deccan.
- C. As the single original cause of Tughlaq decline.
- D. As an event of Muhammad bin Tughlaq's youth.

Answer: A - As a culminating shock that struck a Sultanate already weakened by earlier structural and succession problems.

- A. **Correct.** The invasion of 1398-99 struck a Sultanate already weakened by heredity, faction, provincial autonomy and succession conflict.
- B. **Incorrect.** The Deccan was never recovered, and Timur's invasion postdates Firuz's death by a decade.
- C. **Incorrect.** Decline was already well advanced in the decade after 1388, before Timur arrived.
- D. **Incorrect.** Muhammad bin Tughlaq died in 1351, nearly half a century before Timur reached Delhi.

Trap: Letting a dramatic external invasion absorb an explanation that belongs to the preceding reign's own institutional settlement.

Workbook MCQ 30

Question: Why is the Tughlaq phase historically significant in the larger Sultanate story?

- A. It ended all north-south political contact.
- B. It combined the widest Delhi reach, dramatic over-stretch, Deccan political consequences and important northern irrigation-public-works initiatives.
- C. It eliminated regional states permanently.
- D. It introduced no notable administrative or political shift.

Answer: B - It combined the widest Delhi reach, dramatic over-stretch, Deccan political consequences and important northern irrigation-public-works initiatives.

- A. **Incorrect.** The Daulatabad project intensified north-south roads, migration and cultural transfer rather than ending contact.
- B. **Correct.** The phase combines the widest Delhi reach, visible overstretch, lasting Deccan political consequences and the northern canal programme.
- C. **Incorrect.** The period produced regional states, including Vijayanagara and the Bahmani kingdom.
- D. **Incorrect.** Token coinage, agrarian credit, hereditary iqtas and canal irrigation are all significant departures.

Trap: Measuring the period's importance only by its failures and missing the reach, the transfers and the institutional legacies it produced.

Workbook MCQ 31

Question: The most defensible historiographical line on Muhammad bin Tughlaq is that he was:

- A. a saintly planner betrayed only by fate.
- B. a ruler whose every policy was modern and democratic.
- C. an ambitious ruler with many rational aims whose sequencing, coercion and compliance mechanisms repeatedly failed.
- D. simply insane and therefore beyond analysis.

Answer: C - an ambitious ruler with many rational aims whose sequencing, coercion and compliance mechanisms repeatedly failed.

- A. **Incorrect.** This replaces one moral caricature with another and leaves enforcement failure unexplained.
- B. **Incorrect.** These were coercive medieval measures operating through grain extraction, iqta assignment and command.

- C. **Correct.** Rational aims repeatedly outran sequencing, coercive capacity and the compliance machinery available to the state.
- D. **Incorrect.** The policies carried intelligible strategic and fiscal objectives that a diagnosis of madness cannot explain.

Trap: Answering a caricature with its mirror image instead of with a state-capacity diagnosis.

Workbook MCQ 32

Question: Which assessment of Firuz Shah best survives the evidence of his own reign?

- A. a ruler about whom only European evidence exists.
- B. uninterested in agriculture or towns.
- C. identical in method to Muhammad bin Tughlaq.
- D. a benevolent developmental ruler whose public works coexisted with heredity, orthodoxy and long-run central weakening.

Answer: D - a benevolent developmental ruler whose public works coexisted with heredity, orthodoxy and long-run central weakening.

- A. **Incorrect.** Afif, the Futuhat, inscriptions, canals and monuments are all Indian sources for the reign.
- B. **Incorrect.** The Sutlej and Yamuna canals, the Hissar-Firuza foundation and the department of public works make agriculture and town-building the signature activities of the reign.
- C. **Incorrect.** Hereditary office, the end of audit-torture and an unrevised *jama* are the deliberate opposite of Muhammad's coercive drive for uniform central supervision.
- D. **Correct.** Canals, towns, hospitals and charity are real, and so are heredity, sharper orthodoxy, the slave corps and long-run central weakening.

Trap: Choosing between Firuz the benefactor and Firuz the decliner, when the evidence requires both judgements at different time-scales.

Remediation map - predictable errors and their correcting Workbook MCQs

> The retired standalone remedial bank and the former `Semantic-completeness coverage drills` table are folded into the 32 questions above. Each predictable error below is corrected by the named question rather than by a separate repeated loop.

Predictable error	Corrected by
Delhi was completely emptied for Daulatabad.	Workbook MCQ 03, Workbook MCQ 04
Muhammad bin Tughlaq introduced paper currency.	Workbook MCQ 05, Workbook MCQ 06
The doab crisis was only a higher tax rate.	Workbook MCQ 07, Workbook MCQ 08
Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi tried to farm genuinely barren usar soil.	Workbook MCQ 09
The Khurasan plan and the Qarachil expedition were one venture, aimed at China.	Workbook MCQ 10, Workbook MCQ 11
Muhammad bin Tughlaq was simply a mad or irrational ruler.	Workbook MCQ 31
Chronicle figures and rhetoric can be quoted as audited fact.	Workbook MCQ 14, Workbook MCQ 15, Workbook MCQ 16
Ghiyasuddin's death is a proved murder or a proved curse.	Workbook MCQ 02
Hereditary iqtas strengthened the administration.	Workbook MCQ 19, Workbook MCQ 20
Firuz Shah created a modern welfare state.	Workbook MCQ 25, Workbook MCQ 26
Firuz's canals developed the whole empire equally.	Workbook MCQ 22
Translation patronage proves Firuz was not orthodox.	Workbook MCQ 21, Workbook MCQ 27

Predictable error	Corrected by
Firuz built the whole Qutb Minar and every later north-Indian town.	Workbook MCQ 23, Workbook MCQ 24
Firuz was either militarily inactive or a successful reconqueror.	Workbook MCQ 18
Timur alone caused the fall of the Tughlaqs.	Workbook MCQ 28, Workbook MCQ 29
Vijayanagara and the Bahmani kingdom belong to Topic 05 in full.	Workbook MCQ 12, Workbook MCQ 30
Caliphal recognition gave the Sultan real executive power.	Workbook MCQ 17
Tughlaqabad is decorative rather than political architecture.	Workbook MCQ 01
The slave department was a charitable institution.	Workbook MCQ 25
Firuz is either only a benefactor or only a decliner.	Workbook MCQ 32

PYQ status: one directly routed Prelims question (2021 Q38, official key unavailable locally) and three honestly-adjacent applications; see the ledger below.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PYQ verification ledger and scope honesty

- **PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 (directly relevant; statement wording verified locally; option row partially garbled in OCR, reconstructed only where secure).**
- **PYQ 02 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 (adjacent but directly useful for Tughlaq-era Mongol chronology; wording verified locally).**
- **PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (adjacent source-criticism Mains question; wording preserved verbatim in repository and prior validated packages).**
- **PYQ 04 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (adjacent broader Sultanate-technology question; wording preserved verbatim in repository and prior validated packages).**
- [LIMIT] Official Prelims answer keys for the locally used paper copies are not bundled with the evidence read in this export. Where the repository already uses a high-confidence inferred answer, that status is preserved explicitly as **inferred**, not falsely upgraded.

Verified and honestly-adjacent PYQs

Direct PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 (direct routed relevance; statement wording verified locally; option row partly garbled in local OCR)

Question as securely verified from the local paper OCR: Consider the following statements:

1. It was during the reign of Iltutmish that Chengiz Khan reached the Indus in pursuit of the fugitive Khwarezm prince.
2. It was during the reign of Muhammad bin Tughluq that Taimur occupied Multan and crossed the Indus.
3. It was during the reign of Deva Raya II of Vijayanagara Empire that Vasco da Gama reached the coast of Kerala.

Option row status: The local OCR preserves the options imperfectly, but the repository's earlier validated usage supports the standard combination row containing **1 only**, **1 and 2**, **3 only**, and **2 and 3**.

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: 1 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is correct: Chengiz Khan reached the Indus while pursuing Jalal al-Din Mangburni during Iltutmish's reign. Statement 2 is incorrect because Timur's invasion belongs to the post-Firuz, post-Tughlaq-weakening phase and culminates in 1398-99, long after Muhammad bin Tughlaq. Statement 3 is incorrect because Vasco da Gama reached Kerala in 1498, during the age of a much later Vijayanagara ruler, not Deva Raya II.

Why this earns marks: It secures chronology by dynastic phase and stops the common trap of mechanically pairing "Muhammad bin Tughlaq" with every major north-western episode.

Demand decoding: This is a three-statement chronology-matching item, so the demand is to test each ruler-event pairing separately rather than to judge the set as a whole. Two of the three pairings carry the classic Sultanate-to-Vijayanagara date traps, and the option row itself is only partly legible in the local OCR, so the answer must also declare what is verified wording and what is reconstruction.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Fix each statement to a reign before looking at the options: Chengiz Khan at the Indus belongs to Iltutmish (1210-36); Timur's crossing belongs to 1398-99, a decade after Firuz's death, not to Muhammad bin Tughlaq (1325-51); Vasco da Gama reached Kerala in 1498, long after Deva Raya II. Two eliminations leave statement 1 alone. Close by stating the key as inferred, not official.

How to improve this answer: Add one sentence explaining why statement 2 is the designed trap: both Timur and Muhammad bin Tughlaq are associated with north-western crisis and with Delhi's humiliation, so the candidate who remembers theme instead of decade accepts the pairing. Naming 1398-99 against 1325-51 converts a vague memory into a decisive elimination.

Adjacent PYQ 02 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 (adjacent frontier chronology question; exact wording verified locally)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 1 and 3 (d) 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: (b) 2 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because Mongol pressure predates Jalaluddin Khalji and belongs to an older north-western frontier chronology. Statement 2 is correct because the 1303 Targhi crisis brought Mongol pressure up to Delhi during Alauddin's reign. Statement 3 is unsafe as phrased and is not supported by the secure event-line used in this repository for Muhammad's frontier troubles.

Why this earns marks: It separates general Mongol pressure from specific Delhi-siege events and refuses to validate a statement merely because a familiar Tughlaq ruler is named.

Demand decoding: The item asks which of three Mongol-frontier statements are correct, so the demand is to separate general Mongol pressure on the north-west from specific dated episodes, and to refuse a statement merely because it names a familiar Tughlaq ruler. It is routed to Topic 04 but is retained here because statement 3 tests Muhammad bin Tughlaq directly.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Test statement 1 against the frontier chronology - Mongol invasion predates Jalaluddin Khalji's accession, so it fails. Confirm statement 2 through the 1303 Targhi crisis, when Mongol pressure reached Delhi itself under Alauddin. Reject statement 3 as unsafe on the secure event-line this package uses for Muhammad's frontier troubles. That leaves 2 only.

How to improve this answer: Strengthen the answer by saying what would have made statement 3 acceptable: a named north-western district, a date and a source. Because none of the three can be supplied from the local evidence, the correct examiner move is refusal rather than generous assent, and saying so explicitly demonstrates the elimination discipline the question rewards.

Adjacent PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (adjacent but highly useful source-criticism question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

Persian literary sources are indispensable for the Delhi Sultanate because they preserve the political language, moral anxieties and courtly horizons of the age. Yet they reflect the spirit of the age only when read with **genre, patronage**

and author-position caution.

Topic 05 offers an ideal demonstration. **Barani** is central for Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token currency, Daulatabad, doab crisis and elite theory. But he was a later aristocratic moralist with open prejudice against the "low and ignoble"; his accounts often magnify exemplary success or failure to teach political lessons. **Isami** is useful for Deccan dislocation and Delhi overreach, but he writes from displacement and retrospective memory. **Ibn Battuta** gives vivid evidence on court ritual, punishments, gifts, roads and city-life under Muhammad, yet his traveller's gaze highlights the remarkable rather than the statistically normal. Under Firuz, **Afif** and the *Futuhat-i Firuz Shahi* show public works, benevolence and orthodoxy, but they also stage the ruler's preferred self-image.

These texts therefore reflect not a neutral mirror-image of society, but the **refracted political culture** of their age: ideas of just rule, elite resentment, religious legitimacy, expansion, urbanity and fear. When paired with coins, canals, monuments and inscriptions, they become even more powerful.

Hence Persian literary sources do reflect the spirit of the age, but the spirit they reveal is courtly, argumentative and mediated - never transparent fact.

Why this earns marks: It uses Topic 05's source bank directly, names authors, explains what each source proves, and converts "reflect" into a method question rather than a slogan.

Demand decoding: "Comment" on whether Persian literary sources reflect the spirit of the age demands a direct position on the word "reflect": the answer must decide whether these texts mirror their society or refract it, and must prove the decision with named authors rather than with a general defence of Persian historiography.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open by conceding indispensability and immediately qualifying "reflect". Then run four named units in 250 words - Barani on Muhammad's experiments with his aristocratic moralism; Isami on Deccan dislocation with his displacement; Ibn Battuta on court, roads and punishments with his traveller's preference for the remarkable; Afif and the *Futuhat* on Firuz's works with their self-fashioning. Close on refracted political culture checked against coins, canals and monuments.

How to improve this answer: The weakest move is the generalisation that these texts are "courtly". Replace it with one concrete instance - Barani's line that every Hindu house became a mint - and state precisely what it can and cannot prove: it establishes that counterfeiting was widespread enough to destroy confidence, but it cannot establish how many forgeries existed or where they circulated.

Adjacent PYQ 04 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (adjacent broader Sultanate question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

The Sultanate period mattered technologically not because it created an entirely new civilisation, but because it accelerated the diffusion and combination of techniques in construction, military administration, irrigation and craft production. Their influence was strongest in **state capacity, urban growth and social differentiation**.

In construction, the stronger use of the **true arch, dome and lime mortar** enlarged the scale of buildings and changed the skyline of power. Topic 05's Tughlaq phase reveals a further turn toward battered defensive walls, elevated platforms and large repair projects under Firuz. In irrigation, canals associated with Firuz Shah show technology as agrarian development and revenue policy, not merely engineering. Their impact lay in settlement growth, cultivation expansion and the strengthening of the north-Indian core.

Administrative technology also mattered. Horse-branding, descriptive rolls and revenue audit systems show that information itself was a technology of rule. Even Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token-currency scheme, though it failed, belonged to the same world of technical experimentation tied to fiscal governance.

The social effect was uneven. These changes empowered states, towns, merchants, military systems and courtly centres more than they democratised society. Monumental architecture, canals and money policies deepened stratification even while widening circulation and urban connection.

Thus Sultanate technological change shaped Indian society by linking technique to power, production and urban order.

Why this earns marks: It answers both parts, uses Tughlaq-era examples rather than generic listing, and converts technology into social consequence.

Demand decoding: The question has two explicit parts - which technological changes appeared in the Sultanate period, and how they influenced Indian society - so marks are lost by answering only the first. The demand is diffusion and social consequence, not invention, and the answer must resist listing techniques without tracing who gained by them.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Allocate roughly 120 words to technique and 130 to consequence. Technique: true arch, dome and lime mortar; Tughlaq battered walls and large repair programmes; Firuz's canals as agrarian engineering; horse-branding, descriptive rolls and revenue audit as information technology; token coinage as failed fiscal technique. Consequence: state capacity, urban growth, settlement expansion and deepened stratification. Conclude that technique was tied to power and production.

How to improve this answer: Sharpen the social half by naming who did not gain. The canals benefited villages in the Haryana-Delhi tract that paid *haqq-i-sharb*, while no comparable investment reached the Deccan - so the honest verdict is uneven diffusion, which is a stronger conclusion than the generic claim that technology empowered states more than it democratised society.

Original solved Mains practice

Original Mains 01 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: Assess the importance of Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq's short reign for understanding the wider Tughlaq age.

Model answer:

Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq matters less for duration than for **transition**. He ended the Khusrau Khan crisis in 1320 and restored dynastic legitimacy after the late Khalji collapse. His reign also established the tone from which Muhammad bin Tughlaq later departed.

First, the local OCR stresses Ghiyasuddin's **moderation**: taxation should sustain agriculture and crafts rather than destroy them. This is important because Topic 05 later contrasts it with Muhammad's harder and more uniform fiscal push in the doab.

Second, Ghiyasuddin renewed imperial assertion. Warangal was re-secured through Ulugh Khan and Bengal was campaigned against successfully. Thus Muhammad did not inherit a broken shell; he inherited an energised but still consolidating state.

Third, Tughlaqabad and Ghiyasuddin's tomb announced a new dynastic style - fortified, austere and authority-centred.

Finally, his death after the Bengal return is itself a lesson in source criticism: pavilion collapse is secure, conspiracy certainty is not.

Hence Ghiyasuddin's brief reign is the hinge between Khalji breakdown and the larger Tughlaq experiment in empire.

Why this earns marks: It shows transition, policy tone, imperial handoff and source criticism in one compact structure.

Demand decoding: "Assess" requires a graded verdict on importance, not a narrative of a short reign. The scope word is "for understanding the wider Tughlaq age", so every paragraph must earn its place by explaining something later in the topic - the moderation baseline, the imperial handoff, the dynastic idiom or the method of reading contested evidence.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 150 words use four compact units: 1320 and the end of the Khusrau Khan crisis; moderation in revenue demand as the baseline Muhammad later abandons; Warangal through Ulugh Khan and the successful Bengal campaign as the inheritance passed on; Tughlaqabad and the tomb as the dynastic idiom. Close on the Afghanpur collapse as a source-criticism lesson rather than a whodunnit.

How to improve this answer: Add one sentence making the moderation point do comparative work: Ghiyasuddin wanted cultivators neither rich enough to rebel nor poor enough to stop cultivating, which is exactly the flexibility the standard-yield doab assessment removed. Stating that link converts a descriptive paragraph into the hinge the directive asks for.

Original Mains 02 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: Why should the Daulatabad and token-currency measures of Muhammad bin Tughlaq be analysed as problems of administrative credibility rather than as mere eccentricity?

Model answer:

Both Daulatabad and token currency had intelligible aims, but both required a level of **credible compliance** that the Sultanate could not sustain.

Daulatabad was not random whim. Devagiri was already a strategic Deccan base, and a second-capital model could have improved supervision over the south. The policy failed because migration was coercive, distance was punishing, and the southern direct-rule project itself weakened. The centre could not make the burden appear legitimate for long enough.

Token currency likewise was not absurd in conception. Fiduciary money had wider precedents. The failure came because the state could not monopolise authentication; unofficial imitation spread and trust collapsed.

In both cases, the question is not whether the ruler "had an idea," but whether roads, local cooperation, mint control, public trust and follow-through existed. They did not exist in sufficient strength.

Therefore, these measures are best treated as credibility failures of a high-ambition state, not as evidence of random madness.

Why this earns marks: It links two famous policies through one analytical thread - credibility - and moves beyond stock storytelling.

Demand decoding: The question supplies its own analytical frame - administrative credibility against eccentricity - so the answer must argue that frame rather than restate the two policies. Both halves must be covered, and the verdict must explain why a credibility reading explains more than a personality reading does.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Give each policy about 55 words and reserve 40 for the joint verdict. Daulatabad: prior strategic value of Devagiri, organised road and ward allocation, coercive migration, southern breakaways removing the purpose. Token currency: wider fiduciary precedents, failure of mint monopoly and authentication, redemption in precious metal. Verdict: both required compliance the state could not manufacture.

How to improve this answer: Improve the answer by naming the single shared instrument that failed in both cases - verification. Delhi could not verify who had genuinely migrated any more than it could verify which token coins were official, and saying so turns two anecdotes into one institutional argument that an examiner can credit immediately.

Original Mains 03 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question: Examine how the doab crisis, Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi and the Khurasan/Qarachil episodes reveal the limits of Muhammad bin Tughlaq's state capacity.

Model answer:

Muhammad bin Tughlaq's reign reveals a ruler trying to make a vast empire fiscally legible and strategically secure. The doab crisis, Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi and the Khurasan/Qarachil episodes show that his **objectives were often rational, but his instruments were too brittle**.

In the **doab**, the state relied on standard yield and official prices rather than actual local conditions. Under famine-like stress and harsh collection, the effective burden became explosive. This shows an information problem: the centre could demand, but it could not adapt quickly enough to ecological and local realities.

The **Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi** shows another limit. The objective - extend cultivation and improve crops through loans - was developmental. Yet honest local supervision, agronomic knowledge and recovery discipline were weak. Funds were misused, and the measure failed administratively.

The **Khurasan project** and **Qarachil expedition** display the military side of the same problem. A strategic forward move toward the north-west required sustainable finance and dependable purpose; a mountain campaign required terrain-sensitive logistics. Neither requirement was adequately met.

Across all three cases, the pattern is clear: the Sultanate could imagine larger scales of extraction, improvement and frontier control than it could enforce credibly.

Thus Muhammad's failure was not absence of thought, but a mismatch between imperial ambition and operational capacity.

Why this earns marks: It answers through a common concept - state capacity - and integrates fiscal, developmental and military evidence.

Demand decoding: "Examine" three named episodes means each must be analysed in its own right and then tied to the common concept of state capacity. Treating the doab, Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi and the Khurasan/Qarachil ventures as a single blur of failure loses the marks that come from distinguishing fiscal, developmental and military capacity.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Spend about 60 words on each episode and 70 on synthesis. Doab: standard yield and official prices, *ghari* and *charai*, famine, Swargadwari - an information failure. Kohi: the thirty-kroh tract, about a hundred shiqdars, *sondhar* loans, banjar not usar - a supervision failure. Khurasan and Qarachil: a reported army of 370,000 never launched, and a Himalayan force destroyed by terrain - financial and logistical failures.

How to improve this answer: The answer currently asserts that the instruments were brittle; make it demonstrate this by naming the missing instrument in each case: harvest-responsive assessment, honest local credit officers and terrain intelligence respectively. Three named absences are far more persuasive than one repeated adjective.

Original Mains 04 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question: Discuss Firuz Shah Tughlaq's public works and benevolence. To what extent did they strengthen, and to what extent did they soften, the Delhi Sultanate?

Model answer:

Firuz Shah strengthened the Sultanate in the short run by reorienting rule toward **public works, agrarian recovery and elite reassurance**, but he softened key institutions whose weakness became visible after his death.

On the strengthening side, Firuz built canals from the Sutlej and Yamuna systems into the Haryana-Delhi tract, encouraged new cultivation, founded or renewed towns such as Firozabad and Hissar-Firuza, repaired monuments, built hospitals and organised charity. These measures improved the core north-Indian zone economically and ideologically. They helped present the state as beneficent rather than merely punitive.

Yet the same reign softened the Sultanate structurally. Nobles gained heredity in office and iqta. Soldiers increasingly held revenue assignments and service became hereditary. Audit terror receded, but so did discipline. The slave corps, meant as a pool of dependent manpower, became another political bloc.

Religious legitimacy also came at a cost. Firuz's sharper orthodoxy, separate jizya and temple-related coercion pleased sections of the ulema but narrowed the ideological coalition of rule.

Therefore, Firuz strengthened the **core landscape and immediate legitimacy** of the Sultanate, but softened the **central coercive and administrative edge** on which long-run durability depended.

Why this earns marks: It gives a balanced verdict and measures success in two time-scales - immediate and long-term.

Demand decoding: The stem sets an explicit two-way balance - to what extent did the works strengthen, and to what extent did they soften, the Sultanate. A one-sided praise or critique cannot score, and the conclusion must name the different time-scales on which the two answers operate.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Split 250 words into three parts. Strengthening (about 90): Sutlej and Yamuna canals into the Haryana-Delhi tract, Hissar-Firuza and Firozabad, repairs, hospitals and charity. Softening (about 110): hereditary office and iqta, *wajh* assignments, decayed horse-branding, the slave corps as a rival bloc, sharper orthodoxy and separate jizya. Verdict (about 50): core landscape strengthened, central edge softened.

How to improve this answer: Insert the spatial qualification explicitly: every named work lies in the northern core, and nothing comparable reached the lost southern provinces. That single geographic sentence answers "to what extent" far more precisely than an adjective, and it prevents the familiar error of treating Firuz's canals as empire-wide development.

Original Mains 05 - 20 marks - 250 words

Question: Compare Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah Tughlaq in terms of ambition, fiscal strategy, elite management and durability of rule.

Model answer:

Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah Tughlaq represent two sharply different responses to the same Delhi-Sultanate problem: how to hold together a large and diverse empire from a northern core.

In **ambition**, Muhammad was maximalist. He tried to retain the Deccan under direct rule, experiment with a second capital, push fiscal extraction in the doab, attempt fiduciary coinage and contemplate forward frontier strategy. Firuz was minimalist by comparison: he accepted the loss of the south, did not seek full reconquest and concentrated on a governable northern heartland.

In **fiscal strategy**, Muhammad relied on heavy assessment, standardisation and a bold monetary measure that required strong credibility. Firuz relied more on softer collection, irrigation-led expansion, cesses-remission claims and benefits that often flowed through hereditary office-holders.

In **elite management**, Muhammad widened recruitment, bringing in foreigners and "new men," but this reduced aristocratic cohesion and fed chronicler resentment. Firuz preferred conciliation: high salaries, heredity in office and reduced audit pressure. This bought peace but encouraged oligarchic closure.

In **durability**, Muhammad's innovations collapsed quickly when trust, climate and compliance failed. Firuz's peace lasted longer, but the institutions underneath became softer: the army lost sharpness, nobles entrenched themselves, and succession became fragile.

Thus Muhammad over-strained the Sultanate's capacity, while Firuz undercut its central edge. One failed through overreach; the other through over-accommodation.

Why this earns marks: It compares ruler to ruler across four specified dimensions and gives a nuanced final contrast instead of a moral ranking.

Demand decoding: "Compare" with four named axes is a structural instruction: ambition, fiscal strategy, elite management and durability must each receive ruler-to-ruler treatment. Writing a biography of Muhammad followed by a biography of Firuz forfeits the comparison marks even if every fact is correct.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Use four axis-paragraphs of roughly 55 words each and a 30-word verdict, and never leave an axis with only one ruler in it. Ambition: southern direct rule and frontier offensives against an accepted northern horizon. Fiscal: heavy assessment and token coinage against sharing assessment and *haqq-i-sharb*. Elite: new men against heredity and high salaries. Durability: rapid collapse of trust against slow institutional softening.

How to improve this answer: Add one sentence of common structure before the verdict: both rulers faced the same constraint - the Sultanate could buy reach at the cost of credibility, or credibility at the cost of reach, but possessed no instrument that delivered both. Naming the shared constraint lifts the answer from parallel description to genuine comparison.

Original Mains 06 - 20 marks - 250 words

Question: Historiography often contrasts Muhammad bin Tughlaq as a "visionary failure" and Firuz Shah as a "welfare ruler." Critically examine both labels.

Model answer:

Both labels contain a fragment of truth but become misleading when used without institutional analysis.

Muhammad bin Tughlaq can be called **visionary** only in the limited sense that several of his policies had rational and far-reaching objectives: a more central imperial capital pattern, wider monetary circulation, developmental cultivation and a forward strategic frontier. But "failure" must be explained, not moralised. The failure lay in weak compliance mechanisms - coercive migration without durable consent, token currency without mint control, agrarian development without honest local supervision and strategic projects without stable logistics. The label is useful only if converted into a **state-capacity diagnosis**.

Firuz Shah can be called a **welfare ruler** because he invested in canals, hospitals, marriage assistance, charity, gardens, repairs and urban works. Yet the label becomes romantic if it hides selectivity, political utility and exclusion. Much benevolence favoured core-region and respectable beneficiaries, while the same reign deepened heredity in office, empowered the slave corps, tightened juristic hierarchy and made jizya a sharper marker.

Therefore, neither label should be discarded entirely, but both must be disciplined. Muhammad was not a mad eccentric; Firuz was not a universally benevolent developmental king. Each ruler's reputation becomes historically meaningful only when linked to **who benefited, who obeyed, what instrument was used and what endured**.

Why this earns marks: It turns two familiar labels into a critical historiography answer anchored in evidence and qualification.

Demand decoding: "Critically examine" two historiographical labels means testing what each label captures and what it conceals, for both rulers, before reaching a verdict. Simply rejecting both labels is as weak as accepting them; the marks lie in showing what disciplined use of each would look like.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Devote about 90 words to each label and 70 to the joint verdict. "Visionary failure": concede the rational objectives, then locate failure precisely in coercive migration without consent, token currency without mint control, agrarian credit without honest supervision and frontier projects without logistics. "Welfare ruler": concede canals, hospitals and marriage assistance, then mark selectivity, heredity, the slave corps and separate jizya. Conclude by converting both labels into questions of beneficiary and durability.

How to improve this answer: Strengthen the historiographical dimension by naming where each label comes from: Barani's moralising aristocratic register for Muhammad, and Afif with the ruler's own *Futuhat* for Firuz. Showing that the labels originate in positioned sources - not in neutral assessment - is exactly the critical move the directive demands.